

ASSUMING OFFICE CM Devendra Fadnavis, Gov. Acharya Devvrat and deputy CM Eknath Shinde welcome new deputy CM Sunetra Pawar, Jan. 31

HINDUSTAN TIMES

demise, many of Ajit's legislators could have sought a reassuring leadership figure in Pawar Sr, enabling his camp to call the shots within a reunited NCP. So the caucus thought it best to nip the idea in the bud by arranging for Sunetra's coronation.

THE SPLITTIST VIEW

How close to fruition was the reunion? Versions differ. Sharad Pawar, visibly vexed at the turn of events, told reporters that the entente had been finalised over four months of talks, and a formal merger was to be announced on February 12, a date decided by Ajit. Chief minister Devendra Fadnavis counters that: if the talks had reached the final stage, he says, Ajit would have informed the BJP. Still, the attempts to find a workable relationship were quite public. The two NCPs had even contested the local body elections in Pune and Pimpri Chinchwad in alliance, though unsuccessfully.

Anyway, the deal is off, at least for now, Pawar hinted, revealing he was kept in the dark about Sunetra being chosen as deputy CM. That matches the intent of Ajit's NCP, of which Sunetra might be named president. That front too saw a bit of commotion after Union minister Piyush Goyal said Rajya Sabha MP Praful Patel would take the post. Patel quickly scotched the idea, but the episode served to put the spotlight on a key actor in the drama.

Seen as among the moving forces behind the 2023 NCP split, it's Patel—along with Sunil Tatkare, Chhagan Bhujbal and Dhananjay Munde—who is said to have starred in the present script too. An NCP leader, counted in the anti-reunion camp, told INDIA TODAY that the idea behind elevating Sunetra is to tap into "public sympathy" and firm up a continued viability for the NCP as a standalone entity.

It won't be easy. The swearing-in raised eyebrows, and rival parties did not pull their punches: Sanjay Shirsat, social justice minister from the Shinde Shiv Sena, questioned the haste on display while the state was still in mourning. Analysts see the BJP's hand in the merger being deferred. The ostensible logic: it may contest the 2029 assembly poll alone, and may not want to strengthen a prospective rival. A Congress leader said the BJP would lord it over the NCP, even replace the old guard in the cabinet.

Takeaways

- **Sunetra's swearing-in spoils the proposed NCP merger**
- **Praful Patel leads caucus that aborts Sharad Pawar plan**

Others even predict the party's eventual demise. The rivalry within the Pawar clan is a strong subplot here. In her debut political foray, Sunetra was defeated by Pawar's daughter, Supriya Sule, in the 2024 Lok Sabha poll from Baramati. "The personal bitterness persists," says a Shinde Sena source.

But there's a deeper undertow. If Ajit pursued a reunion in the face of family opposition, insiders say, it's because he was impelled by the fear that the BJP would gradually eat into the space of its allies. Ideologically, he had held out against Hindutva, in sync with the anti-Brahminical vein of his Maratha base. The NCP's existential fears do not die with him. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

Bengal's Radical Double Whammy

An outspoken pair of polarisers—one Hindu monk, one Muslim renegade—heat up poll skillet

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

MURSHIDABAD, THE OLD CAPITAL of Bengal's nawabs, has never been shorn of its centrality in modern politics—given the creatively functional role it reserves for the communal question. Even its pre-2014 social temperature charts, albeit relatively stable, were marred by a few violent spikes. In the past decade, it attained an even lower boiling point. Last April, in fact, saw a widespread conflagration sweep the frontier district, becoming Bengal's headline political event for weeks.

With that baseline set, it's logical that today it plays host to a pair of polarising figures who have reared into prominence with eerie simultaneity. One Hindu, one Muslim, quite the opposite sides of the same coin—together, they promise to keep the skillet scalding hot for this summer's election.

Call heads, and you get Kartik Maharaj, formally Swami Pradiptananda of the Bharat Sevashram Sangha in Beldanga, who fits the old trope of a saint with a bristlingly militant tongue. Inter alia, he has